CHAPTER 1

Kingly Trajectories

The chronological scope of this two-volume project, namely AH 490s–610s, overlapping with the twelfth century of the Common Era, has been determined by the Shansabanis' appearance in historical records, and their imperial rise, expansion and *dénouement* along these temporal lines. The current volume focuses on the Shansabanis' early history; their initial expansions beyond Ghur-Zamindawar (see maps, pp. xv and xvi); and their fracturing into separate, geographically distinct lineages (see Genealogy, p. xvii) – a confederate empire – all taking place during *c.* AH 510–580s/1120s–1180s CE (cf. Chapters 3–5). The emphasis of the present volume, then, is on relevant events dating to approximately seven decades of the twelfth century in what is modern Afghanistan. Such a specific temporal and spatial focus might imply that a historical overview of the early Shansabanis would be largely a question of recapitulating the information in textual sources and existing scholarship. In fact, this is far from the case, for reasons that are historical as much as they are historiographical.

Although obviously never devoid of "history" per se, nomadic and transhumant groups rarely encountered the need to record in written form the events constituting their past. The challenges of recuperating oral histories are well known, moreover, especially as orally transmitted narratives underwent "translation" upon becoming written.[1] Concomitantly, the court-centered nature of most imperial chronicles and other textual sources meant that nomads and other transhumant populations received only passing references, their appearances in texts occasioned primarily by interaction with the hegemonic "state" in a particular region.[2] Indeed, the elision – if not erasure – by contemporaneous textual sources of the nomadic past even of the great Saljuqs (tenth–twelfth centuries), and a parallel silence regarding the continuation of non-sedentist mores in their imperial phase,[3] are all amplified in the case of the geographically remote Shansabanis. But, in addition to being a question of general historical import, a view of the Shansabanis during the late eleventh–early twelfth centuries – even in broad strokes – furnishes important data to bear in mind as the later rulers' trajectory broadened into an imperial arc, encompassing the valleys of the Indus and ultimately the plains of northern India (cf. Chapter 6 and Volume II).